POLITICS | India Monologues

IDEAS OF INDIA: On Being Muslim in India

LT GEN. ZAMEER UDDIN SHAH (RETD)
Former Deputy Chief of Army Staff, former VC, Aligarh Muslim University

SONG OF UNITY

BANDEEP SINGH



KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The diversity of India is non-negotiable and has to be celebrated
- The anonymity of social media has enabled people to air what they feel like. It has affected a small part of retired officers of the armed forces
- India, with its humanist credo, has extended support to disaster-hit people across the world
- If one is educated, one faces less discrimination. Muslims, especially girls, have taken to education in a big way

Speaking on the topic of 'Being Muslim in India', former deputy chief of army staff and former vice chancellor of Aligarh Muslim University, Lt Gen. Zameer Uddin Shah (retd), opened with a rousing 'Jai Hind', a call that privileged no caste, religion or creed—his idea of India. He said that India's strength was the unity she possessed through her diversity and added that his family background of Sufism and years in the army had insulated him from communalism. The army reflects the idea of India, he added, and its loyalty to the Constitution is derived from its Preamble: 'We the people'.

Shah singled out social media as a major source of affliction in the country as its anonymity allowed people to make hateful references. On an optimistic note, he said the idea of India was marked by deep roots and flexibility that render most disturbances as passing phases, ensuring that the idea of India holds. ■

> **Affirmative action has been displaced by appeasement. Appeasement is help expecting a return favour. If appeasement of the minority is incorrect, can appeasement of the majority be condoned?**